

AP

THE SHEHBAZ SHARIF-LED PDM COALITION IS ANGRY AT HAVING TO BEAR THE BRUNT OF KHAN'S ECONOMIC MISMANAGEMENT, WHICH MIGHT HURT IT POLITICALLY

Khan will eventually be arrested or will have to surrender before the courts, but nothing could illustrate the impotence of the Pakistani state better. Despite court orders, Khan has been skipping court hearings, using the excuse of threats to his life during court appearances, of his leg injury from a gun attack early last November and—according to his own lawyers—of haemorrhoids that make it difficult for him to sit for long or travel long distances. Yet, at the same time, he seems well enough to lead, and not be worried about threats to his life during, rallies in the heart of a city with thousands more mobbing him.

THE CASES AGAINST IMRAN KHAN

PTI spokesmen claim that over 83 FIRs have been registered against Khan so far (though there are 37 cases in which he is said to be directly involved), which they claim are an attempt to divert the party's attention from impending elections and have their leader caught up in running from court to court. But while some of the cases are indeed superfluous and probably instituted by the government only as irritants, other major ones are far more substantial and have the potential to affect Khan's political career.

Two of these cases are coming up for hearing this month with non-bailable arrest warrants—one relating to profiting from foreign state gifts and another related to his verbal attacks on a female judge, where he is accused of committing contempt. In the former—known as the 'Toshakhana' case—he is accused of having sold off a Saudi-gifted watch and other jewellery worth millions of dollars without first declaring it or purchasing it from state coffers, and then lying about it and allegedly attempting a cover-up. Indictment in either could lead to a disqualification from contesting elections.

A third case pertains to not declaring his alleged daughter Tyrian White—with the late American socialite Sita White—in his official declarations. The story has done the rounds for decades but, this time, if Khan is shown to have misdeclared his alleged paternal links in official filings, it could lead to him being disqualified from politics under the law pertaining to "moral turpitude".

A fourth, far more important case in its potential, involves allegations that the PTI diverted funding from prohibited sources, including from foreigners, and even monies meant for Khan's charitable trusts—such as the Shaukat Khanum Memorial Cancer Hospital—towards political activity. This case, while still ongoing, has the potential to severely dent or cripple the entire prospects of Khan's party.

But why the focus on Imran Khan and his PTI? To put it very simply, since his ouster in a vote of no-confidence last April, Khan has been the bane of the Pakistan Democratic Movement (PDM) coalition government that replaced him, as well as the establishment. He has sowed the seeds of political chaos in Pakistan, with inflammatory speeches and conspiracy theories at a time when